



Crystals & Pixels

LCDs continue to get cheaper as more people adopt a flat panel. Which brings up the inevitable dilemma of a choice. That's where we come in

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No two LCDs are created equal, the adage goes. From the type of panel used, to the grade of the panel used, to the integrated electronics and processing included — all contribute to changes in display output characteristics and this difference is akin to the difference between

night and day.

With a vast majority of manufacturers just looking to move volumes in bulk, very little attention is paid quality, given its inverse relationship to price. A group of five models with similar panels will be made to look different with body styling, a few features will be changed around and voila — you have five different products, five different product categories, at five

varying price points. Another trend is to overstate specifications and manufacturers frequently flirt with dishonesty. A good example being the term *dynamic contrast ratio*, a well hated bit of jargon in our test centre. It's misleading to the core, for a monitor stating a DCR of 60000:1 is typically found to have a contrast ratio of 600:1, or less. Another example is the *true* number of reproducible colours. Yet another

example — brightness levels on LCDs. Some people are more honest, but it's hard to know what and whom to believe, and when.

We're pleased to note a continuing trend towards larger screens. Eight out of twenty monitors were 23/24-inches in size. Another trend is the move towards 16:9 as an aspect ratio in lieu of 16:10.

As for the people who didn't make it here — HP didn't wish